

IT'S BUSINESS AS usual on a balmy Wednesday afternoon at a cricket academy in Chennai. The coach attends to parents dropping by for enquiries, even while keeping a sharp eye on a bunch of youngsters practising batting drills at the nets. On the side, he keeps his laptop open, ready for him to jump into an office call on Zoom or MS Teams whenever his US client needs him.

Confused? What's a cricket coach doing with a laptop for 'office calls'? And we're not talking about calls with cricket authorities here. Well, this particular 'coach' is actually a senior-level UX designer at a leading multinational IT company. The cricket part is his passion, something that he has been able to indulge in thanks to the flexibility of remote work his office allows. The coach has been playing out this 'double role' on most days since June 2021, when he realised his dream of setting up his own centre to teach children cricket. His routine: log in at 10 am, attend a few office calls, have lunch, go to the ground by 3 pm, and juggle office work and coaching duties till 7 pm.

"My boss knows about it, although I didn't take any explicit permission from my employer. I think it is not required because it's not a competitor. Hybrid work allows me to be at the academy as well as do my office work," says the 41-year-old, requesting anonymity. He is not entirely sure if what he does constitutes moonlighting (which is essentially doing jobs or projects not connected with one's employer). His workload is manageable, he feels his productivity hasn't dropped, and his boss is aware of his side venture. He says a few of his colleagues are even pursuing acting on the side.

The practice of moonlighting is not new; it has been

around for ages and will likely continue. But there has been a baseline shift. Earlier, people would indulge in their passions or side projects (on the sly) mostly during weekends and holidays. But new-age moonlighting, spawned by the pandemic's hybrid/remote work paradigm and its inherent flexibility, has brought weekdays and official work hours also into play. Ergo, the example of the cricket coach and his open laptop.

Still, things would have continued without a ripple, but for Wipro Chairman Rishad Premji's tweet on August 20 about moonlighting being "cheating—plain and simple". His comment, clearly aimed at employees doing work on the side for competitors, snowballed into a fierce debate in India's \$150-billion-plus software exports industry. Should it allow its 4.5-million-strong white-collar workforce to take up income-generating side gigs or not?

Industry voices have mostly been critical of it. Premji has since said that Wipro fired 300 employees found moonlighting for competitors. TCS COO N. Ganapathy Subramaniam sees it as a long-term loss to the industry, while CHRO Milind Lakkad has called it an ethical issue. And IBM India MD Sandip Patel finds dual employment "not ethically right". Infosys has warned that employees caught moonlighting will be fired as it is unethical to take up a second job 'during or after work hours', while RPG Enterprises Chairman Harsh Goenka has backed Wipro in a tweet: "If the customer finds even a remote chance of data compromise, it will not be tolerated."

But moonlighting also has its proponents. Tech Mahindra MD & CEO C.P. Gurnani is supportive of the idea and has said he would introduce policies to enable employees to be more open about it. Former Infosys CFO and Board Member T.V. Mohandas Pai has said it doesn't amount to cheating. And Union Minister of State for Entrepreneurship, Skill Development, Electronics & Technology, Rajeev Chandrasekhar, said: "Efforts of companies to pin their employees down are doomed to fail". Meanwhile, Sanjeev Sanyal, member of the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister, in a tweet, wondered how it could be an ethical issue if it wasn't about data privacy.

What, really, is moonlighting? Let's take the dictionary route first. The Cambridge Dictionary defines moon-

“YOU CANNOT STOP ANYONE FROM MOONLIGHTING. FIRST, YOU MUST PAY PEOPLE BETTER IN THE FIRST FIVE YEARS OF THEIR CAREER BECAUSE RIGHT NOW THEY ARE EXPLOITING PEOPLE

MOHANDAS PAI FORMER CFO AND BOARD MEMBER, INFOSYS